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Tightening a sport to the rhythms of broadcast demands often calls for innovation. The viewers — or perhaps more accurately, the viewership numbers — reign supreme, dictating the ‘product.’

The Pro Kabaddi League is no exception. Now in its 12th chapter, the league already looks very different from the amateur global version of the sport. A sophisticated multi-camera setup and a steady stream of tweaks to balance raiders and defenders have reimagined a rustic, indigenous game for modern audiences.

The latest changes seem to draw heavily from cricket, particularly the IPL. Draws have been scrapped, replaced by a Super Over-style tiebreaker for the league stage. The knockout phase has also shifted: instead of the top two teams going straight to the semifinals, the IPL model of a qualifier ensures the losing side gets another chance to reach the final.

Points have been simplified, too. Gone is the system of five points for a win, three for a draw, and one for a close loss. In its place: a straightforward binary of two points for a win, none for a defeat.

“The long-drawn nature of the league meant a lot of teams were raising concerns about players tiring out. Injuries are also a major point of worry for the tournament as a whole. So we’ve made the league stage a bit shorter. This will also make proceedings more competitive,” technical director E. Prasad Rao tells *Sportstar*.

The new format increases the incentive to finish higher on the table, rather than simply sneaking into the knockouts and coasting.

Fresh water flows

This season is also the first without any of PKL’s original superstars. Pardeep Narwal’s retirement marks the end of a golden generation and the beginning of a wide-open contest.

Iranian powerhouse:

Mohammadreza Shadloui Chiyaneh, the Iranian allrounder and two-time PKL champion, now brings his match-winning edge to the Gujarat Giants. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

